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Louis-Etienne Dubois, Chris Gibbs,

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Video game—induced tourism: a new frontier for destination marketers

Louis-Etienne Dubois and Chris Gibbs

Louis-Etienne Dubois is Assistant Professor at the School of Creative Industries, Ryerson University, Toronto, Canada. Chris Gibbs is Associate Professor at the Ted Rogers School of Hospitality and Tourism Management, Ryerson University, Toronto, Canada.

Abstract

Purpose – *This paper aims to expand the media-related tourism literature in a new domain of application by highlighting a connection between the world of video games and tourism.*

Design/methodology/approach – *Through deductive content analysis, this study looks at 137 online comments posted on popular gaming and travel websites that connect two popular video games (Assassin's Creed II and Assassin's Creed Unity) and travel motivation.*

Findings – *Results establish that video games share similar travel motivation elements with film and should be considered as a driver of tourism. It argues that destinations should consider video games as a platform for motivating tourists before they consider investing in virtual reality. It outlines opportunities for destinations interested in video game-induced tourism and calls for more research and case studies that link video games with destinations.*

Originality/value – *This is, to the authors' knowledge, the first paper to investigate this connection. As such, it outlines untapped opportunities for destinations interested in video game-induced tourism and opens up a new line of research within media-related tourism literature.*

Keywords Video games, Film-induced tourism, Media-related tourism, Travel motivations

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

Media-related tourism, broadly defined as visits or travel to places associated with books, authors, television and film, has been extensively studied in the past 20 years (Gartner, 1993; Busby and Klug, 2001; Iwashita, 2008; Mercille, 2005; Lee *et al.*, 2008). The way different media shape images about destinations and influence tourism is of interest both from a marketing and a cultural standpoint. However, the literature tends to focus on a limited number of media, namely, on film and television's (TV) ability to attract tourists through the portrayal of place and storyline (Beeton, 2006; Grihault, 2007; Joliveau, 2009; Riley *et al.*, 1998).

As a result, an even bigger media's impact on tourism has yet to be studied. On equal footing in terms of cultural relevance (Smith, 2011) and production costs with film and TV (Codère, 2016), video games represent a \$100bn and fast-growing industry (Newzoo, 2017). Of interest is the fact that many of today's games explore the virtual geography of cities and let players roam like tourists. Whether it is a walk around Paris in *Assassin's Creed Unity* or a drive through the streets of San Francisco in *Watch Dogs 2*, games enable players to experience cities in original ways.

This study attempts to make a theory-building contribution by advancing the conceptualization of media-related tourism through an original case application (Dooley, 2002). Specifically, using deductive content analysis (Krippendorff, 1980; Elo and Kyngäs, 2008), we review online entries for evidence of tourism-related activities associated with two popular city-based video games. The study's starting point and theoretical anchor is the

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most documented form of media-induced tourism to date. For film and TV-induced tourists are defined as “people seeking sights or sites seen on the silver screen” (Busby and Klug, 2001, p. 316), we demonstrate that some people *equally* seek sights or sites seen in games and, therefore, establish the first evidence of “video game-induced tourism”. Our results expand the media-induced tourism literature into a new domain of application and open up what we believe is a promising line of research. This study is also relevant to destination marketers who may seek to collaborate with video games companies to enhance their sense of place, promote their brand and highlight the long-term tourism financial and visibility opportunities for destinations associated with video games.

Literature

Film and television-induced tourism

Global competition for tourist spending calls for a better understanding of traveler motivations. Such deep understanding leads to better planning, efficient marketing campaigns and increased visitor retention (Hsu and Huang, 2008). Travel motivations are a commonly researched topic within tourism and have yielded many models and frameworks: Allocentric-psychocentric Model (Plog, 1974, 1987), Travel Career Patterns (Lee and Pearce, 2002, 2003; Pearce, 2005), Escaping and Seeking Dimensions (Mannell and Iso-Ahola, 1987) and Push Pull Factors (Dann, 1977, 1981; Crompton, 1979; Zhang and Lam, 1999; Jang and Cai, 2002; Hsu and Lam, 2003).

While much research related to motivation focuses on mass tourism, interest for unique markets that hails from the association with popular media is strong (Iwashita, 2008). These “autonomous agents” shape mental representations that, in turn, influence the destination selection process for travelers (Gartner, 1993). Among this stream of research, the influence of film and TV is especially well documented. According to Croy and Walker (2003), they generate awareness, desire and action to visit screened locations by forming images and expectations in the minds of the viewers. As a result, out of the estimated one billion people who travel for pleasure each year, one in five are said to be for film or TV-induced tourists [ACFI (Association of Film Commissioners International), 2016]. For destinations, such motivation has significant direct and indirect economic impacts. Hudson and Ritchie (2006) mention the Wallace Monument in Scotland, which witnessed a 300 per cent increase in visitors after the movie *Braveheart*, or the TV series *Dallas* that still draws 500,000 visitors annually to Texas 25 years after its final episode. Mercille (2005) shows how many travelers’ first experience with Tibet was through Jean-Jacques Annaud’s 1997 popular motion picture *Seven years in Tibet*.

Promoting picturesque environments generates awareness, familiarity and curiosity for a destination (Croy and Walker, 2003). As a result, film and TV’s strong impact on different motivators can be used purposefully to drive individuals to visit a destination (Gartner, 1993). Dann’s (1977) model of travel decision suggests that destination can chose to “push” a location by showcasing its assets or play on one’s internal motives, which include ego enhancement, fantasy, status and prestige, self-actualization self-identity and vicarious experiences to “pull” potential visitors. The impulse may also come from family members such as children who influence their parents’ travel decisions after watching TV show for kids (Connell, 2005). While there is not one universally agreed upon conceptualization (Fondness, 1994), the push/pull model has been widely used within tourism research related to media (Gjorgievski and Trpkova, 2012). Hall (2003) also suggests authenticity as a key motivator, that is, the idea that destinations should provide meaningful and unique individual experiences to visitors. Film-induced tourism covers not only attracting visitors but also on-site activities. For instance, Roesch (2009) explains that film tourists engage in photo taking, capturing and comparing filmed sites, re-enacting scenes, as well as in dressing like the characters. Therefore, some scholars like Beeton (2006) have argued that film tourists’ motivations often relate to obsession and to a “cult of celebrity”.

Combining the different perspectives, [Macionis \(2004\)](#) breaks down the motivations into three categories: the serendipitous film tourist, the general film tourist and the specific film tourist. The first refers to those who just happen to be in a destination portrayed in a film and whose motivations revolve mainly around social interaction. The second includes those not specifically drawn to a film location but who participate in related activities to seek novelty, education and nostalgia. Finally, the specific film tourists are those who actively seek out places seen in film and are motivated by self-actualization, pilgrimage, self-identity, fantasy and romance ([Figure 1](#)).

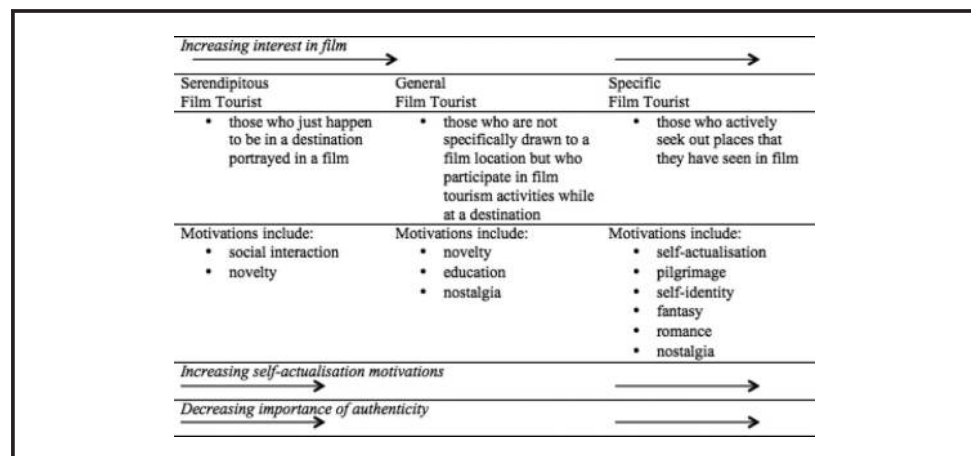
From a marketing standpoint, film and TV can convey comprehensive messages and images, an unlikely achievement for traditional shorter forms of promotion ([Croy and Heitmann, 2011](#)). As such, Canada and the Bahamas have identified film tourism as a marketing opportunity and have hired public-relations firms to gain exposure through TV and film ([Hudson and Ritchie, 2006](#)). Promoting hotels and houses featured in films as places to stay can also increase the number of tourists, as such lodging links back to the internal motivation of living vicariously through a film's character and the obsession with celebrities. As an example, the Crown Hotel (Amersham, UK) promotes the room used in *Four Weddings and a Funeral* ([Hudson and Ritchie, 2006](#)).

While film and TV generate awareness and recognition of destinations, they do not constitute the sole motivation for visits. [Hudson and Ritchie \(2006\)](#) suggest that research on psychological and behavioral aspects should be pursued to maximize marketing methods and economic benefits. [Beeton \(2006\)](#) also calls for a better understanding of the film-induced tourist by studying the range of consumer drivers at play. Additionally, despite clear economic benefits, film tourism comes with drawbacks; these include increased traffic, pedestrian congestion, loss of privacy for locals and destruction of the natural environment ([Tooke and Baker, 1996](#)). It can also lead to a decline in regular tourists or create a negative image for a community ([Croy, 2010](#)).

The case for video games

While many people's experience with video games may be limited to that of a "plumber who saved the dainty princess" ([Goldberg, 2011](#), p. 9), the industry's evolution over the past decades should not be overlooked. With global sales expected to reach \$109bn in 2017, video games have become a creative heavyweight ([Newzoo, 2017](#); [Smith, 2011](#)). AAA games, the equivalent of Hollywood blockbusters, can cost up to \$250m to produce, far outspending TV series such as HBO's *Game of Thrones* ([Nayak, 2013](#); [Codère, 2016](#)). It is

Figure 1 Macionis's (2004) film-induced tourism model



also not uncommon for games to outperform film releases. Grand Theft Auto IV (Rockstar Games) made \$800m in its opening weekend, three times what Star Wars: The Force Awakens (Buena Vista), the all-time film leader for opening weekends made (Nayak, 2013; Box Office Mojo, 2017).

Despite impressive numbers, video games hardly generate interest in the tourism industry. One possible reason is that games are still seen as a marginal, teenage-boy hobby. Yet, according to industry figures, 65 per cent of US households own a console, and the average player is 35 years old (ESA, 2016). Far from being a niche market, the global industry caters to 2.2 billion “gamers” (Newzoo, 2017). Another reason could be that the technology is not advanced enough to recreate cities properly. Then again, industry reviews often point out to the realism and fidelity of games, arguing that “you can now visit cities [...] and believe you are really there” (Fox News, 2014). A third potential explanation could be that games are not engaging and as likely to convert consumers into visitors. However, *Assassin’s Creed Unity*’s players logged an astonishing 16,000 years worth of game time in the first six months following its release (Moser, 2015). Additionally, unlike the shorter and finite duration of film or TV, players can spend upwards of 60 h in a game (Snow, 2011). Whereas film or TV are passive media that rely on the absorption of content by viewers, video games generate active participation and immersion (Pine and Gilmore, 1998). As opposed to simply providing entertainment and esthetic experiences, games aspire to educate players and offer escapism. In other words, games exert a strong motivational pull through appealing and highly engaging environments (Ryan *et al.*, 2006).

On the other hand, the core principles behind video games have long permeated tourism through so-called gamification. By definition, gamification refers to “the use of game design elements in non-game contexts” (Deterding *et al.*, 2011). In the case of tourism, it includes adding ludic and game-like elements to increase engagement, visitor loyalty and destination awareness (Sever *et al.*, 2015). It enhances the overall travel experience by awarding points, levels, badges, rewards and status, while tapping into intrinsic motivators through socialization and challenge (Xu *et al.*, 2013a, 2013b). In addition to gamification, mobile games offer real potential for destination marketers. Tourists can access information about a given destination, branded trivia and challenges before or during visits to generate more engagement (Xu *et al.*, 2015). Some destinations have even begun to use augmented reality (i.e. akin to the *Pokemon Go* game) to create unique “geo-fenced” experiences for visitors. For instance, Tuscany has developed a mobile application that delivers interactive and real-time content to tourists during their visits (Spadoni *et al.*, 2011).

For destination marketers and tourism-industry professionals, overlooking video games while embracing its principles seems contradictory. The possibility that video games could do for tourism what TV and film have done in the past 30 years warrants further investigation.

Methodology

According to Dooley (2002), theory building also encompasses the application of existing theory to original cases to advance it. By applying the media-induced tourism theory to new domains, we seek to further refine and expand the current body of literature. Through deductive qualitative content analysis (Krippendorff, 1980; Elo and Kyngäs, 2008), we examine game-related tourism online entries. Content analysis is common in tourism research (Stepchenkova *et al.*, 2009). For instance, Dann (1995), and later Macionis (2004), have used it to investigate travel motivations, while Malloy and Fennell (1998) surveyed codes of ethics to identify common principles in tourism. Deductive coding, or “coding down”, as used here, is theoretically driven and quantifies occurrences based on existing categories (Dann, 2005; Glaser and Strauss, 1967).

First, we selected two video games set in specific cities that are accessible to tourists. Set respectively in fifteenth-century Florence (Italy) and eighteenth-century Paris (France), *Assassin's Creed II* (ACII) and *Assassin's Creed Unity* (ACU) have been developed by Ubisoft and have sold millions of copies worldwide. The former focuses on Ezio Auditore da Firenze, an assassin seeking to restore his family's name, and allows players "to explore renditions of major Italian cities through a mixture of action, stealth, and economic gameplay" (AC Wiki). This includes climbing buildings, walking on rooftops and performing "leaps of faith" from various viewpoints. The latter centers on Arno Dorian's quest to avenge his father's death. Throughout this journey, players visit detail-oriented renderings of Versailles and Paris, including the city's catacombs and the Notre-Dame Cathedral. Completing the games takes on average 26 h, providing players with ample time to "experience" the cities (Howlongtobeat, 2017).

Second, we surveyed the Web for tourism-related reviews and comments (entries) in which these games (Assassin's Creed, AC II, ACU) were explicitly mentioned and compiled them in a Microsoft Excel spreadsheet. As per Elo *et al.* (2014), we collected data only from the most relevant sources concerning our research topics. As such, three online sources were purposefully selected:

1. *Reddit*, a popular online platform where technology enthusiasts gather;
2. Ubisoft's online blog dedicated to the AC franchise, in which avid players share their experiences; and
3. *TripAdvisor*, an established source that does not cater only to video game players.

Keywords such as "visit, visiting, tourist, tourism, travel, travelling" were used to scan through the entries and weed out non tourism-related posts. In total, 137 unique entries (Table I) matched our criteria, namely, 83 entries for *Reddit*, 17 entries for Ubisoft's blog and 37 entries for *TripAdvisor*. Out of those entries, only 100 depicting real-life experiences (not just virtual) were subsequently analyzed.

Third, to build on the current literature, we built a coding frame (correspondence matrix) using Macionis' (2004) film-tourism typology (serendipitous, general and specific). The assumption being that proceeding from an existing body of literature and finding similar manifestations – people mirroring travel motivations of people with other media – would suffice to postulate the existence of a relationship between video games and tourism. Fourth, entries were independently reviewed and coded by the two authors to increase the results' trustworthiness (Elo *et al.*, 2014). Initial agreement was 84 per cent, a rate deemed highly reliable (Lavrakas, 2008). Discrepancies were discussed and full agreement was reached in a follow-up analysis. Results are presented in Table II and discussed.

Table I Source of online data and number of entries studied (n = 137)

	<i>Reddit</i>	<i>Ubisoft AC Blog</i>	<i>TripAdvisor</i>
Entries reviewed	83	17	37

Table II Coding correspondence between film-tourist categories and entries

<i>Source</i>	<i>Serendipitous</i>	<i>General</i>	<i>Specific</i>	<i>Other</i>	<i>Total</i>
Reddit	5	11	30	37	83
Ubisoft AC Blog	3	2	12	0	17
TripAdvisor	15	9	13	0	37
Total	23	22	55	37	137

Results

The results suggest a connection between video games and travel. Upon coding, 23 per cent of the entries identify relate to [Macionis' \(2004\)](#) serendipitous tourism category, 22 per cent to the general tourism category, while the remaining 55 per cent can be described as specific tourism entries.

Serendipitous video game-induced tourists

Serendipitous tourists visit a destination portrayed in TV or film by coincidence. They discover associations without intentionally seeking them out ([Macionis, 2004](#)). Social interaction is a key motivational driver, as highlighted by this Trip Advisor entry about the Piazzale Michelangelo:

Great spot to drink beer and chill with friends. Pros include live music, great views of the city, several photography spots, if you play Assassin's Creed you'll recognize a few noticeable spots from there. Great spot for a new profile picture if you're into selfies. (TA-SE-1)

It is common for this type of tourist to be traveling with friends without a clear purpose, as mentioned in this entry: "I went with friends just after having played Assassin's Creed (happy accident) and was blown away" (RE-SE-1). Similarly, this student happened to spot ACII during a school trip: "This day two years ago I was on my way to Rome with my school [...] Make sure to admire the work of the architecture and how similar Assassin's Creed II design is to the real thing" (RE-SE-5). In addition, an individual within this category mentioned: "In Rome, I was also completely blown away. Seeing buildings like the Castel Sant'Angelo in real life just blew my mind. Replayed Assassin's Creed right after I came home" (RE-SE-3). Another one was in Florence to film a documentary when he recognized the Duomo from ACII:

We stopped in front of the Cathedral to look at it [...] we walked all around it, and at one point, I saw the bell tower off to one side, and the cables that ran to the top of the Cathedral roof from the buildings beside it, and I thought, Hey! I climbed over to the roof just that way when I was playing Assassin's Creed 2! (TA-SE-9)

Similarly, another individual wrote:

I've been to Venice prior to AC2 and to Florence, Monteriggioni, San Gimignano and Siena shortly after the release – although this was a mere coincidence, it was absolutely stunning to find places in the AC2-Venice I knew as well as discovering landmarks in the other cities I knew from the games. (UB-SE-1)

Although games are not the reason that serendipitous tourists visit a destination, these tourists are impressed to see first-hand landmarks previously experienced virtually in the game. They also clearly establish and communicate about the connection between video games and destinations.

General video game-induced tourists

General tourists are not drawn to a destination because of TV or film but still participate in related activities while visiting ([Macionis, 2004](#)). Novelty, education and nostalgia are the key motivational drivers, as highlighted by this entry: "If you ever played Assassin's Creed 2 like myself, then you'd be stoked to actually see this magnificent structure. Well even if you haven't, this would still stop you in your tracks and leave you amazed" (TA-GE-4). In terms of nostalgia, a tourist participated in game-related activities by purchasing branded memorabilia and photographing them: "I spotted a stand selling AC shirts, so I decided to buy it for a few Euros and take a photo in front of it" (RE-GE-9). Along the same lines, one individual reflected on his virtual experience while visiting the Cupola del Brunelleschi:

I had virtually seen and climbed this Cupola in Assassin's Creed and finally had the chance to see it for real! It was a great experience to view this piece of art, especially from the hills outside of the city from which you can see how massive it is! Probably one of the most amazing monuments in Europe. (TA-GE-8)

Other entries relate to education and highlight how games can facilitate the on-site experience:

I had never been to Florence and Venice before and even though the cities in AC aren't exact replicas, I managed to find my way around these cities and find certain landmarks by knowing their layout from AC2. (UB-GE-2)

Another individual wrote: "My kids were able to point out every inch of this building. Why? Because they have played the video game Assassin's Creed. Who said video games are not educational? All kidding aside, this is an unbelievable building. The details and colors are amazing [...]" (TA-GE-7). Although games are not the reason for general tourists to travel, their experience appears to be enhanced by the time spent playing, as expressed again in this entry: "Brotherhood definitely made my trip to Rome a thousand times better. Looking up at the colosseum like I've climbed and jumped off it!" (RE-GE-11).

Specific video game-induced tourists

Specific tourists actively seek out places they have seen in a film (Macionis, 2004). In the case of ACII, one individual wrote: "Ezio [lead character] is the main reason I chose Italy as my holiday destination" (UB-SP-8). Similarly, another entry said: "When I went to Italy my only interest in visiting was because of AC and it still remains the absolute best place I've ever been" (RE-SP-24). Another individual expressed his game-related excitement: "I am going to Firenze tomorrow. Anywhere you guys would recommend me to go, like Assassin's Creed related? I am really excited, and 99 per cent of that excitement is because of AC2" (RE-SP-18). Of Macionis' (2004) three categories, specific tourists are the most driven: self-actualization, pilgrimage, self-identity, fantasy and romance are all powerful motivations to travel. A consistent theme is connecting their real-life experiences with the game and visualizing themselves as the protagonists. One individual who visited Florence because of ACII wrote:

It's just like Assassin's Creed except the Duomo now has a marble facade making it significantly harder to climb the exterior. So you will have to line up with hundreds of other tourists for hours to synchronize your maps. And then once you're on the top, there is a cage to stop people from jumping off with a leap of faith. They're a bit short of haystacks in the plaza nowadays. My eagle vision told me to instead go to Piazzale Michelangelo because there's less people, free, and a better view. (TA-SP-2)

Mentions of climbing, synchronizing maps, jumping with a leap of faith, haystacks and eagle vision – all actual features of the game – are connected to his real-life experience. One individual even went as far as to embody the main character by dressing like him: "I went to Italy in March 2013, with an Ezio costume" (RE-SP-10). Another explained that the "Assassin's Creed series inspired me to visit Rome. Thus, I want to ask you all [...] the best places to visit Rome and re-live Ezio Auditore moments" (RE-SP-26). One entry also stressed the importance of embracing the full AC experience while on site: "You don't want to feel rushed, otherwise you won't enjoy spur of the moment, things like stopping in the middle of a street looking upwards and seeing in your mind's eye Ezio expertly jumping from rooftop to rooftop" (UB-SP-1). Similarly, this tourist reflected on AC while on top of Giotto's Campanile (bell tower):

If you love Assassin's Creed, you will be so excited to climb this architectural wonder. When I was in the area just before the top, the wind whipped past my ears I smiled and I looked out the

windward knew just where my next move would be if I were standing on the roof of the Basilica of Santa Maria del Fiore. (TA-SP-7)

Taking it even further, one individual re-enacted the protagonist's action, as explained by a bystander familiar with the game: "This Friday a wannabe Ezio climbed the Doge's palace in Venice. Immediately he started to climb the statues and columns next to the palace's portal, then he climbed back down and went away undisturbed" (RE-SP-9). Along the same lines, one player displayed enthusiasm for planning a trip to meet with other ACII fans and to celebrate the game:

Like once a year, a whole bunch of people dressed in various interesting clothes descend upon the city and spend the whole day walking around ominously – some running, some taking to the rooftops, some perching on things [...] choreograph some "show-duels" on the streets for people to spectate. (RE-SP-5)

These dedicated experiences do not appear to be uncommon. In fact, one participant recalls the flow of ACII tourists during his trip in Italy: "At every location I visited, I would mention to the staff at the different landmarks that I was visiting Italy based on Assassins Creed, and in every location, they would say, "oh really? you're not the only one!" (UB-SP-4).

Discussion and implications

Media influence destination image and representations, and in turn, impact actual travel. This phenomenon, known as media-related tourism, has historically focused on film and TV cases. From the textual evidence reviewed, we demonstrate that video game players who are exposed to images of Florence and Paris also seek out, to various degrees, related activities within the cities, hence mirroring [Macionis' \(2004\)](#) different categories of film tourists. This is, to our knowledge, the first description of this sizeable media's potential to generate "video game-induced tourism".

Using existing constructs allowed us to not venture completely blind in this unexplored topic. Macionis' work provided a framework to qualify both the nature and the intensity of these early indications of tourism induced by video games. Indeed, some players do engage in shallow activities only after realizing the linkage with the game, while others actively seek the full experience. While the primary contribution of this research uses textual evidence to identify the linkage of tourism motivations with video games, the findings make for an interesting parallel with film and TV. [Beeton \(2006\)](#) used terms like "obsession" and "cult" when discussing the motivations of film tourists. Similarly, these "specific" tourists could be considered to be obsessed with the game because it is dictating travel decision-making. They are looking to extend their virtual experience by visiting the actual setting of the city where the game is based.

As with other media, those exposed to this new type of "autonomous agents" ([Gartner, 1993](#)) appear to be influenced in both their destination selection process and in their experience on site. Akin to Macioni's general category, some tourists explained that their ability to get around in the city was due to their time "playing it". This is perhaps the most important difference with film and TV: spending upwards of 20 or 30 h in a realistic and interactive reproduction of a destination is something that can hardly be matched by other media. It could be argued that representations and motivations are amplified by the fact that players are active participants and have a say in what they get exposed to and for how long. This could also explain why the breakdown between Macioni's categories is heavier on specific tourists with games: players are not simply exposed to Florence and Paris, they roam in it, jump around, escape traps, encounter characters and pursue unique mission. Macioni's idea of "pilgrimage" takes all its meaning here.

"Gamers" participate in travel activities that mirror virtual experiences. Dressing up, comparing screenshots to actual landmarks, climbing on monuments, acting like the main

protagonist – they are definitely invested and driven by the media. Such enthusiasm also generates what we could call “collateral game tourists”: friends and loved ones who are talked into – or dragged into – visiting a destination because of passionate gamers. Entries often mentioned that the decision to travel originated from teenagers or partners invested in the games, akin to [Connell's \(2005\)](#) findings on toddlers' influence on parents. As such, and building on [Macionis' \(2004\)](#) work, our results suggest a fourth category of game-driven “collateral” tourists who end up in a given city because of a gamer. The 37 “other” entries that did not pertain to a real-life visit could also be of interest if destinations found a way to monetize such touristic inclination and generate real visits.

For destinations already featured prominently within video games, film and place promotion strategies, such as themed festivals, social-media engagement, and representations related to a game can help generate measurable tourism activities. As [Gjorgievski and Trpkova \(2012\)](#) explain, while tourism is often the “unintentional consequence” of media, destinations should nonetheless develop “intentional strategies” to capture some of the value generated. Even a small percentage of the world's millions of gamers could end up representing a significant uptake for some destinations, that is, provided that dedicated offers and activities are developed for them. While popular movies have become the subject of multimillion-dollar theme parks, unique attractions could also be developed for games. If this seems far-fetched, it should be noted that the gaming event ComicCon (San Diego) has an economic impact of \$150m ([David, 2016](#)).

Within destination marketing, film commissions may start to approach game producers, as they would film producers to attract both production dollar and awareness. While the direct financial impact of production is unlikely to match the level of film and TV, indirect contributions in the form of awareness and tourism cannot be overlooked. At the very least, destinations should consider assigning dedicated resource to this media with a role akin to a film commissioner. If video game tourists are indeed more of the “specific” type, having a “game commissioner” could help generate and then translate this passion into tourism revenues. For instance, an in-house video game expert in Florence could study the ACII universe and come to conclusion that players interested in the game are also likely to be interested in the Medici family or Da Vinci (actual characters in the game), Renaissance weapons or secret societies. This commissioner could in turn channel online and physical traffic to existing tourism offers related to these topics.

While more work is required to quantify gaming's economic impact in a similar way that [Hudson and Ritchie \(2006\)](#) have done for film and TV, developers may seek to be compensated for showcasing destinations. As production costs rise, seeking financial support from cities seems inevitable. Such collaboration may however come with drawbacks. First, studios may not be as free to omit buildings, use a different scale, or take other “artistic liberties” if constrained by a marketing mandate to represent a destination faithfully. Yet, these risks can be mitigated through guidelines and potential benefits outweigh artistic constraints. For example, developers could gain “behind the scene” access to monuments or archives to enhance the games.

Second, destinations may have to deal with undesired behaviors (trespassing, climbing on buildings, etc.) or be reluctant to be associated with a violent game. However, *Braveheart* and *Lord of the Ring*, often cited in film-induced tourism, also feature blunt violence. In addition, many games limit random violence by either “desynchronizing” players (aborting) or by removing the feature altogether. Reminders of players' limitations and of differences between the virtual and the real-life experience could nonetheless be more visible.

Limitations and conclusion

Limitations to this study must be acknowledged. First, it focused on popular travel destinations; findings could be different for other cities, especially the less popular ones. As

Busby and Klug (2001) point out, the measure of media-induced tourism is less likely to be hampered by other variables in rural areas. Second, the analysis was limited to English-language comments, although the games are distributed in multiple languages. As a result, a relatively small sample size makes it difficult to generalize the findings. Finally, examining only text-based comments may not be fully representative due to people's different motivations for posting comments.

While the linkage between tourism and media is well documented, no research had demonstrated the linkage between tourism and video games. Drawing from the rich film and TV-induced tourism literature, this study has not only uncovered signs of players traveling after having played a game but also suggested that a majority of them traveled *specifically* because of it. For this is only the first attempt to postulate this linkage, future studies could also borrow existing media-related tourism tools or constructs to track and quantify this phenomenon further.

Practical implications for this research intersect destination marketing and video game production. Similar to how destinations pursue film production as an economic benefit from both production dollars and positive images generated by the media, we suggest a closer collaboration between the two. Given that video games will continue to be a part of the popular media landscape, and with some early indications that gamers are "specific" tourists, developing proactive strategies and roles to attract them as travelers seems inevitable for destination marketers.

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Corresponding author

Louis-Etienne Dubois can be contacted at: le.dubois@ryerson.ca

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